Bullshot Crummond

By Ron House, Dix White, Jake Neville-Andrews, Alex Shearman, and Derek Cunningham

SUGGESTED ROLES: *Both actors provide sound effects as necessary. Otto and Lenya have pronounced, over-done German accents; All others have pronounced, over-done British accents.*

ACTRESS: *Lenya, Rosemary, Algy, Policeman (Otto in scene with Crummond)*
ACTOR: *Otto, Fenton, Crummond, (Lenya in scene with Rosemary)*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Dramatic music begins. The sound of an aircraft engine is heard. The engine begins to splutter. The loud crash of the plane is heard. Heavy music swells.

OTTO: *(unrolling a map)* We seem to have crashed in the right location. Over there is Netherington Abbey, and there is the town of Tunbridge Wells. And that light over there is from the home of one Professor Rupert Fenton!

LENYA: The famous British scientist?

OTTO: Yes! Who has just made a rather interesting discovery!

FENTON: *(The voice of PROFESSOR RUPERT FENTON is heard Off stage.)* Hello! Is anybody there?

OTTO: As I planned. The noise of our crash has attracted his attention.

FENTON: *(He enters. He is carrying a flashlight.)* Hello. Well thank goodness you're safe. I saw your flying machine crash with a deuced big bang.

OTTO: Professor Fenton!!

FENTON: That's strange. How did you know my name?

LENYA: My father and I know many things about you, Professor

OTTO: Including your recent discovery

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OTTO and LENYA: Ha! Ha! Ha! Ha! Ha! *(They hustle FENTON off Right. Sound cross-fades to quiet dawn music.)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *The dashing Captain Hugh "Bullshot" Crummond - WWI ace fighter pilot, Olympic athlete, racing driver, part-time sleuth and all-round spiffing chap.*
ACTOR: *(in character) Men want to be like me and women want to be with me!*
ACTRESS: *Or, at least, that is the public perception. Whilst he is, indeed, a remarkable man, he is also a bumbling buffoon.*
ACTOR: *(in character) And it is I who must save the world from the dastardly Count Otto van Bruno, my wartime adversary.*
ACTRESS: *This parody of low budget 30s detective movies typifies British heroism.*
ACTOR: *Don't miss the next thrilling installment of this dastardly tale of*
TOGETHER: *Bullshot Crummond by (alternate authors names) Ron House, Dix White, Jake Neville-Andrews, Alex Shearman, and Derek Cunningham*

CRUMMOND: Wait a moment. What's this? *(He bends down and picks up an "imaginary" blade of grass from Center Stage.)*

ALGY: It's a blade of grass, Crummond

CRUMMOND: *(Examining the grass.)* Yes, Algy. But there's a smudge of petroleum on it

ALGY: Well a tractor probably passed this way.

CRUMMOND: Since when have tractors been using high octane aviation fuel? *(Music sting.)* Look. A footprint. And another. A man's and a woman's. There's been a scuffle round here by the look of things. But why, Algy? Why? I smell intrigue! *(He strides manfully off Left. Two sections of the bush Upstage swing apart and OTTO peers out from behind it.)*

OTTO: So! Crummond is on to us. Meddling fool of an Englishman-still with a nose for intrigue. But this time, Captain Crummond, you will be nipped in the bud!l *(Blackout. Music swells.)*

[Later that day] CRUMMOND in dressing gown and pajamas posed in silhouette. He is smoking his pipe. Lights build as he opens the door and enters. Moving in time to the music he picks up a letter from the breakfast tray, opens it and glances through it. As the music ends he folds up the letter and strikes a pose with his leg on the chair Center.

CRUMMOND: Extraordinary! *(Reading the letter.)* "My dear Captain Crummond. I am in terrible trouble, and need your help desperately. My father has recently disappeared, following a mysterious airplane crash!" Mmm! Yours in distress," *(He examines the letter.)* No name! No

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address! *(Smells letter.)* Scented notepaper! *(Holds letter up to the light.)* Family crest watermark! *(Reads.)* "In Libris Fentonium Sempere Sum"-In Liberty I Am Always Fenton! Fenton! Now there was a Willy Fenton who served under me in France, and he used to write to his sister named Rosemary. Must be her! But I wonder what the deuced sort of trouble she'd be in?. . . Which makes me wonder what our old friend [Otto] Von Brunno is up to at this very moment. *(Turning front.)* Hmmmmmmml *(Blackout. Dramatic music swells. End of Scene)*

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OTTO: *(Into radio.)* Black Baron to Iron Fish ... over! Black Baron to Iron Fish come in ... This is Count von Brunno. I am pleased to report that we have captured the British professor Fenton and will rendezvous at Smuggler's Cove at 0300 hours as arranged ... Good ... Over and out Now nothing can interfere with my plans for my conquest of the whole world. *(A figure wanders across the stage with a flashlight –her back to OTTO – searching nervously . . . does not see Otto until she backs into him).* Can I help you?

POLICEMAN: Ooh. You gave me quite a turn. Sorry to disturb you sir! We've had reports of radio signals being transmitted to a German submarine from this area.

OTTO: *(In a thick German accent.)* What! Here on the British coast?

POLICEMAN: I'm afraid so, sir. Looks like spies. You didn't happen to see any foreign looking types pass this way did you?

OTTO: No, I have seen no one.

POLICEMAN: Well, don't worry sir, I'm sure we'll have them by morning ... *(OTTO yawns.)* Oh, I must have got you out of bed. Well - goodnight …

OTTO: Gute nacht *(Clicks his heels.) (OTTO crosses and looks off after POLICEMAN. LENYA enters)*

OTTO: *(Still looking off.)* You see how easy it is to deal with the British police.

LENYA: Otto! This whole scheme is ludicrous! I want to go back to Germany! I want to go to my favorite nightclub- I want to wear furs- I want to wear diamonds ...

OTTO: *(Producing an enormous diamond from his pocket.)* Like this, Lenya? I

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LENYA: Otto! From where did you get such a beautiful diamond?

OTTO: They were not so difficult to-MANUFACTURE! *(Music sting.)*

LENYA: Manufacture?

OTTO: Yes, Lenya! Although flawless in every way they are synthetic. *(He pronounces it "sinsetic.")*

LENYA: *(Same pronunciation.)* Synthetic!? Ah . . . It is all beginning to make sense.

OTTO: With these jewels, we will be able to ruin the international diamond market -

LENYA: Thus causing mass unemployment -

OTTO: Starvation!

LENYA: Hunger!

OTTO: Poverty!

LENYA: And death to thousands of innocent people. *(Crossing to OTTO.)* Ohl Otto - I'm so happyl When can we begin?

OTTO: *(Hesitating.)* There are some formalities. Crummond is on to us! *(End of scene – Music swells as they exit)*

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After a few moments the music fades and high frequency electronic sounds are heard. Seconds later FENTON is heard screaming in agony and writhing in pain. Over his head is a silver wired dome which is attached to the back of the chair. OTTO stands Upstage Center at the controls of a large electronic panel. LENYA stands Left of the chair. After a few moments the lights stop flashing as OTTO switches off the controls.

OTTO: Well, Professor? Will you manufacture the diamonds?

FENTON: No! Never! I'll never agree!

OTTO: No, Professor? *(He switches on the machine and the lights flash even more. FENTON screams. After a few moments FENTON passes out.)*

LENYA: Stop, Otto! He's unconscious!

OTTO: *(He switches off the machine and the lights stop flashing. Lights fade up to a brighter level.)* If *he* will not manufacture the diamonds, then we must obtain the formula from him!

LENYA: Yes! Then we can manufacture them ourselves. But we will need a new approach.

OTTO: Precisely! *(He picks up a syringe from the control desk.)*

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LENYA: Ah! Cranial Stimulant X!

OTTO: Yes! The most effective truth serum known to man!

FENTON: Do you realize that even the smallest overdose will cause brain stagnation?

OTTO: *(Smiling menacingly.)* Of course, Professor! *(OTTO gives FENTON a shot in the arm. He becomes still for a few moments then starts writhing about jerkily.)*

LENYA: It's taking effect!

OTTO: He can no longer resist answering our questions!

LENYA: Professor! Where is your formula!?

FENTON: *(Meekly.)* In-my-desk-at-The Larches.

OTTO: *(Sigh of success.)* Aaaah! I must go to "The Larches" immediately, and get the formula.

LENYA: No, Otto! You may be recognized. It is better that entice Miss Fenton here with the formula!

OTTO: But Crummond will surely follow her

LENYA: No! Because the Professor is going to make a little telephone call *(Crossing Left.)* Professor! We want you to telephone your daughter-inform her that you're safe and send Crummond back to London.

FENTON: No! I won't do it-and you can't make me!

OTTO: We won't have to professor! Because I happen to be an expert at Vocal Re-Iteration. *(He picks up a telephone from the control desk.)* Hello! Give me ze Larches, please! *(Taunting FENTON.)* It's ringing! *(Otto fakes Fenton's voice)* Hello, Rosemary! It's me, your father. Nol I'm alright. Staying with friends at Netherington Abbey. I want you to London Hugh Crummond send. What? No! Bad line! Goodbye! *(Turning to FENTON.) Well*, Professor! You made the 'phone call af .. *(Reverting to his own voice.)* ter all, didn't you? *(OTTO laughs. Blackout. Music swells.)*

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As the music fades and lights come up ROSEMARY is speaking on the telephone to whom she believes to be her father.

ROSEMARY: Daddy, where are you? Oh, you're safe. Yes, I will. Goodbye. *(to Crummond)*

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Hugh! It was all a false alarm. Daddy's safe at Netherington Abbey. I'm so happy. And Daddy said you should go back to London. I'm sorry to have wasted your time.

CRUMMOND: Just a minute, Rosemary. Your father didn't know I was here. What were his exact words?

ROSEMARY: His exact words were, "I want you to London Hugh Crummond send."

CRUMMOND: A split infinitive! Now, there's only one language that uses that with such annoying regularity - GERMAN.

ROSEMARY: But Daddy doesn't speak German.

CRUMMOND: He didn't have to, Rosemary, because it wasn't your father who telephoned. Von Brunno! Using vocal reiteration. Don't you see, Rosemary, your father is being held prisoner at Netherington Abbey.

ROSEMARY: What are we going to do now?

CRUMMOND: We'll have to rescue him, but we'll need a plan of attack. Now, there's not a moment to lose. The Von Brunnos want you to take the formula to Netherington Abbey. So that's exactly what you're going to do.

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The Dungeons of Netherington Abbey. Sabers on wall. As the lights come up LENYA enters followed by an apparently frightened ROSEMARY.

LENYA: *(Actor assumes the persona of Lenya for this scene)* Ah! Come this way, Miss Fenton. Did you come alone?

ROSEMARY: Yes! Captain Crummond isn't with me. He's gone in his Bentley to London, and won't be back until next week.

LENYA: So! Give me the formula!

ROSEMARY: No! I won't!

LENYA: Ah! So you do have it?

ROSEMARY: Yes! And you have Daddy! Against his will, no doubt!

LENYA: Don't be silly! He's our guest-and perfectly safe. *(PROFESSOR FENTON screams from offstage.)*

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ROSEMARY: That sounds like Daddy-and you're hurting him ! You're perfectly beastly!

LENYA: Just give me the formula.

ROSEMARY: Very well-here it is! But you must promise to stop hurting Daddy!

LENYA:*(Bored.)* I promise! *(Takes formula.)* Now I will get your father! Take a seat until I return!

(LENYA exits Upstage Center. ROSEMARY feigns crying for a few moments. She stops and. looks around. Moves Right and makes strange bird call. An even stranger call replies from offstage followed by CRUMMOND'S entrance)

CRUMMOND: Well done, Rosemary! They've swallowed the bait, hook, line and sinker!

ROSEMARY: What will happen when they discover the formula isn't genuine?

CRUMMOND: Mayhem, Rosemary! Well, you've done your part famously, but from now on, it's man's work! There's not a moment to lose-take off your clothes!

ROSEMARY: I beg your pardon Hugh!

CRUMMOND: I need them as a disguise, the Von Brunnos will be back at any moment.

(Rosemary and Crummond transition off stage)

LENYA: *(She enters with FENTON.)* In there, Professor. Miss Fenton, here is . . . Miss Fenton! Miss Fenton, it's no use trying to hide. *(CRUMMOND emerges from behind screen dressed in ROSEMARY'S clothes.)*

CRUMMOND: *(In ROSEMARY'S voice.)* Are you alright, Daddy? *(Lenya rolls her eyes and leaves)*

FENTON: Rosemary! Thank goodness you're safe. But what are you doing smoking a pipe?

CRUMMOND: It's not Rosemary, sir, I'm Hugh Crummond.

FENTON: Another of Von Brunno's henchmen I suppose-and you've taken Rosemary's clothing you perverse swine. *(He tries to wrestle with CRUMMOND but faints.)*

CRUMMOND: No sir, you don't understand ... hang it, he's fainted. Rosemary I must get your father out of here immediately. I'll be back as quick as a wink. Come along Professor, homeward bound for you. *(Pantomimes picking up FENTON in a fireman's lift and carries him out.) (Music. OTTO and ROSEMARY enter. Music fades.)*

OTTO. *(angrily)* Miss Fenton! I want the genuine formula . . . *(ROSEMARY and OTTO circle the table. She picks up her handbag and throws it at him.)*

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ROSEMARY: You beast!! Captain Crummond!!

CRUMMOND: *(Off.)* I'm on my way, Rosemary! *(He dashes in)* Von Brunno! Sly as ever

OTTO: *(actress assumes the persona or Otto for the remainder of the scene)* Yes, indeed, Captain! *(He draws a sword from the panel Left.)*

CRUMMOND: Oh, come now! Surely even you would give me a fighting chance?

OTTO: Very well, Captain. Defend yourself. *(Throws him a sword.)*

CRUMMOND: Now stand clear, Rosemary. This may be bloody! *(ROSEMARY runs out.)* I do feel I should warn you, Von Brunno, that I was varsity champion at Cambridge. *(They fight across the Stage.)*

OTTO: I think not, Captain! *(He knocks CRUMMOND to the ground, takes his saber and points his own at CRUMMOND'S throat.)*

CRUMMOND: A classic example of German honor-running a man through when he's down!

OTTO: Well, I could hardly deny a dying man his last request. Very well, Captain. Stand up!

CRUMMOND: Alright, Von Brunno. *(He raises his hands.)* You've got me this time-I will admit it!

OTTO: *(Takes luger out.)* You have a reputation for cunning, Captain Crummond-so I warn you-no tricks!

CRUMMOND: But there is just one small thing you seem to have forgotten. . . .

OTTO: What is that, Captain? ... *(CRUMMOND dives for the gun. They wrestle. Otto is shot – actress reassumes the persona of Rosemary).*

ROSEMARY: Oh Hugh, you've finished off the Von Brunnos. You've rescued Daddy and you've saved the formula! And you did it all for me ... Hugh, you're wonderful.

CRUMMOND: Not wonderful, Rosemary .... Just BRITISH!

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AWARD HISTORY

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